

A La Carte

By AL CARTWRIGHT

Sports Editor

CLEARWATER, FLA., MARCH 31.—YOU WALK UP to an old ball-player and ask him "What was your biggest boner?" And you get a variety of answers. They range from Joe Garagiola's barrage of rocks—he came up with three and was digging for more when the game started—to Frank Crosetti's aiming all 21 guns of that copyright-Yankee dignity.



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Garagiola has written a book called "Baseball Is A Funny Game," and to the catcher turned-broadcaster, it is.

Coach Crosetti may or may not have known about the book, but his answer to the question was: "To me, baseball isn't a funny game, and I don't think mistakes should be dug up and kicked around again for laughs. Everybody makes mistakes—ball players, druggists, writers, bankers—and they're better off forgotten. I'd like to accommodate you, but that's the way I feel about it."

Your privilege, Frank. But Garagiola and a lot of other used talent weren't so stuffy. Joe told us about the time he nonchalantly started catching a game for the Pirates until a polite cough from the umpire, Dusty Bogges, let him know that he had forgotten his mask. And the day in Brooklyn when Joe came up for the Cardinals with the bases loaded. He topped the ball down the first-base line, took a few steps and decided it was going foul. Gil Hodges came racing in, picked up the fair ball, tagged Garagiola and threw to the screaming Roy Campanella at the plate for a forceout and a double play.

"I wouldn't say this boner had anything to do with it," Garagiola winked, "but the next day I was traded to the Pirates."

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Moses Upsets Manager

WALLY MOSES WENT BACK TO '32 AND A HOT afternoon—that sounds like a safe assumption—in Vicksburg, Miss. He was playing for the visiting Monroe club in a Cotton States League match.

"I batted third, and our cleanup hitter was a fellow named Pyle," the Cincinnati coach recalled. "He led the league in everything—hitting, homers, RBI's. Late in this game, I came to bat with the bases loaded and nobody out and drew a count of three balls, no strikes. I hit the next ball for a triple to right-center, which I thought was pretty neat. But by the time I got to third the manager, Pop Kitchens, was practically having a stroke in the coaching box."

Whitey Lockman, fellow Cincinnati coach, was a pigeon for the mossy hidden-ball trick—and in the majors, of all embarrassing spots. Lockman had doubled for the Giants and Connie Ryan of the Braves asked him to step off the bag at second so that it could be straightened.

"I did," confessed Lockman, "with the expected results. I didn't get too much criticism from the manager, though. He was coaching third. Man named Leo Durocher."

Eddie Stanky, though, felt the Durocher bite his first year with the Giants. The Giants were losing by two with two out in the ninth when Stanky banged a hit down the line in left and decided to try for two bases. He was thrown out at second and that was the game.

"My run didn't count, as Leo informed me later," the Cardinals' personnel director said. "I got a real good taste of The Lip—my very first. But he waited until the next day to do it, which I appreciated. I was no shrinking violet, you know, and knew I had pulled a rock. I wasn't about to pack up and go home on account of it."

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Waner's 'Steal' of Second

PAUL WANER ONCE TRIED TO STEAL SECOND WITH the bases loaded, which is pretty hard to do, as the Phillies' batting coach now realizes.

"I came up for the Pirates with Kiki Cuyler on first base and my brother Lloyd on second," Waner winced.

"I hit a line-drive single to right center and just took it for granted that Lloyd scored and Cuyler moved to third. I never even noticed they had moved up only one base each—until I took off with the next pitch and made a beautiful slide into second. As soon as I started sliding, I saw those Pittsburgh stockings on second and knew something had gone wrong."

This grand hitter of Pittsburgh's palmy days figured in Andy Cohen's biggest boner.

"When I was playing second for the Giants, it was my greatest desire to double up the Waner brothers," the Phillies' new coach said. "Sure enough, I get the chance. Lloyd is on second and Paul hits me a lovely double-play ball. I make a dandy stop and cut loose with a hard throw to second. However, it seemed that there already were two out. The throw sails by Travis Jackson, our shortstop, out into left field and Lloyd scores."

Kerby Farrell, the Buffalo manager, laughed that "I never pulled a boner in my life." But Ellis Clary, Washington coach, suggested that we ask Farrell about the time he was managing Indianapolis from the third-base dugout and one of his players got caught in a rundown between home and third.

"Farrell got so excited he kept inching away from the bench and on to the field," Clary insisted, "Pretty soon both Farrell and the runner were caught in the same rundown."